

Before You Access

From an account-access avoidance idea to a fast frontline resolution-routing assistant.

Role Product discovery, user research, product strategy, prototyping	Research 20 interactions collected; 19 usable for analysis
Validation 5 live workflow scenarios tested against the prototype	MVP constraint 1-3 questions; target 30-45 seconds

Outcome: Discovery changed the product from a binary 'access / don't access' checker into a lightweight routing assistant that balances self-service, Retail capability, channel ownership, and customer effort.

The challenge

Frontline retail interactions move quickly, but the correct resolution path is not always obvious from the customer's opening request. A digital option may exist but be impractical in the moment; account access may be necessary for diagnosis but not final resolution; and some requests belong to another support channel.

Portfolio note

This is an independent portfolio project informed by frontline telecom retail experience. It is not an official T-Mobile product or endorsed internal tool. The public case study uses no customer data, internal APIs, confidential documentation, or proprietary screenshots.

I started with the wrong-sized problem

The first hypothesis focused on reducing unnecessary account access. Research showed the workflow was more nuanced.

Original hypothesis

A short pre-access qualifier could help representatives avoid low-value account interactions, surface self-service paths, and protect interaction-based performance metrics.

89%	42%	53%	30 min
17 of 19 involved account access	8 of 19 generated Complete Points	9 of 17 accessed interactions generated no Complete Points	Median reported interaction duration

What the data changed

- **No Complete Points did not mean unnecessary account access.** Returns, account changes, fulfillment, payments, upgrades, and other legitimate workflows could require access without generating points.
- **Self-service potential was real, but conditional.** Six of 19 interactions were clearly self-serviceable, while four were clearly resolvable by the rep without account access.
- **Intent alone was a weak routing signal.** Two customers asking about similar device issues could need different paths depending on authentication, fulfillment, or available workarounds.

Research integrity: 20 frontline interactions were collected. One response was excluded because of questionable response quality, leaving 19 usable interactions for analysis.

Cutting features was part of the product work

Discovery also showed that several early ideas overlapped with tools and processes that already existed.

Initial idea	Decision	Why
Broad knowledge / promo assistant	Remove	Existing knowledge tools already cover policy, promotion, and documentation lookup.
Manager task / training tracker	Remove	Dedicated management tooling already tracks tasks, deadlines, and training completion.
Standalone coaching tracker	Deprioritize	Existing coaching workflows already provide substantial follow-through context.
Access / no-access wizard	Reframe	Binary guidance could not represent self-service viability, Retail capability, or channel exceptions.

Reframed product question

How might we help frontline employees quickly determine the most efficient resolution path for a customer - and recognize when that path needs to change?

New product principle

Choose the lowest-effort appropriate resolution path while avoiding unnecessary account access. The goal is not to maximize self-service at all costs; it is to make the right route obvious quickly.

Live scenarios exposed the missing variables

Rather than polishing v1, I tested its assumptions against real frontline workflows.

Scenario	What v1 missed	Product implication
Damaged foldable device	Damage did not automatically require account access.	Check whether authentication and claim/self-service tools are still usable.
Samsung settings help	Technical complexity did not equal account-specific work.	Rep knowledge gaps should not trigger account access by default.
Unexpected bill / cancellation	Account access helped diagnose the issue but Retail could not complete cancellation.	Account access and channel ownership are separate decisions.
Replacement eSIM	A self-service path technically existed but required extra people and delay.	Self-service availability is not the same as self-service viability.
Screen protector replacement	A 'validation-only' route added no value once verification created the interaction.	If Retail can complete the need, complete it; do not optimize for artificial distinctions.

Key realization: The customer's opening intent is not enough. Routing depends on whether self-service is viable now, whether a quick workaround exists, whether Retail can complete the need, and whether a known channel exception applies.

Simplify the decision, not the underlying problem

The redesign deliberately reduced the number of decisions a rep must make during a live interaction.

Hard usage constraint

1-3 questions maximum. Target: 30-45 seconds.

Every tap must earn its place. If two answers lead to the same route, the question should not be asked.

1. What type of help? Account / Device & Service / Purchase & Fulfillment
2. Ask only the route-changing question Self-service option? Known exception? Best path right now?
3. One follow-up only when needed Example: Is the digital path blocked? Do both COR accounts already exist?
Recommended path Self-Service / Assisted Self-Service / Complete in Retail / Customer Care / Fiber Customer Care

Frontline language over product language

The interface was also rewritten for scanning speed. Product concepts such as 'customer friction' remain useful in the case study, but the live interface uses plain choices such as **Digital**, **Retail**, **Digital is blocked**, and **Is there a self-service option?** Descriptions provide context for newer employees without slowing experienced employees.

Retail is the default; exceptions change the route

A generic 'Can Retail complete this?' question was removed because Retail can handle most requests.

Request	Route	Decision rule
Line cancellation	Customer Care	Retail does not complete line cancellation.
Change of Responsibility	Retail or Care	If both accounts already exist, Retail can complete it. If a new receiving account must be created, route to Care.
Fiber - new setup / initial scheduling	Retail	Retail can support new Fiber setup and scheduling.
Fiber - existing service	Fiber Care	Troubleshooting, rescheduling, cancellation, and ongoing support route to Fiber Customer Care.
Most other account-required needs	Retail	If verification or processing creates the interaction and Retail can complete the need, finish the resolution in Retail.

Design requirement: Simple enough for a newly trained employee; fast enough that a tenured employee will actually use it.

Why this matters

The same interface can serve experienced representatives as a decision accelerator and newer representatives as a decision guardrail. Detailed policy and process guidance should remain in existing knowledge systems rather than turning this product into a policy encyclopedia.

The MVP is a checkpoint, not a claim of product-market fit

The current prototype is intentionally small enough to test the routing model before investing in deeper development.

What this project demonstrates

- **Discovery over attachment:** the original solution was challenged rather than defended.
- **Scope discipline:** redundant features were removed when existing tools already solved them.
- **Iterative validation:** five live scenarios exposed failure modes that the initial tree could not represent.
- **Product simplification:** complexity moved into the decision model while the frontline interface became shorter and faster.
- **Research integrity:** excluded low-quality data was disclosed, and validation scenarios were kept separate from the original research sample.

What I would test next

Measure	Question
Time to decision	Can users consistently reach a route within the 30-45 second target?
Routing confidence	Do reps feel more confident about the recommended channel/path?
Tenure comparison	Does the same flow work for both newly trained and tenured representatives?
Misroute rate	Which scenarios still produce the wrong destination or unnecessary account access?

Current MVP:Prototype v2.5 - a functional browser-based decision assistant with a 1-3 question routing flow.
Next investment: usability and workflow validation, not additional feature expansion.

[Try the live prototype >](#)

Interview summary: I began with an account-access hypothesis, gathered frontline evidence, found that the problem was more nuanced than expected, removed ideas that duplicated existing tools, built a lightweight prototype, tested it against live workflows, and simplified the product into a fast resolution-routing assistant.